

DISANN KATENDE, MPH

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Hiring Committee

Information Management Strategy and Policy Branch, Digital and Analytics Strategy Division
Ontario Ministry of Health

Re: Information Management Policy Analyst — Job ID 247975

I am writing to apply for the Information Management Policy Analyst position with the Information Management Strategy and Policy Branch. I am a research epidemiologist and public health data analyst with 12 years of experience turning health data and research evidence into recommendations for policy, program, and funding decisions, most recently as a Research Epidemiologist with the World Health Organization and previously with First Nations Health Authority, BC Children's Hospital Research Institute, and CAREX Canada at the BC Centre for Disease Control. I am based in Toronto and would welcome the opportunity to bring that experience, and a direct, working understanding of how health data is collected, linked, and governed, to the Branch's data strategy and policy work.

As Pacific Region Representative on the CIHR/PHAC Community Advisory Committee, I advise CIHR and PHAC on community-identified research priorities and provide strategic feedback on research proposals and funding priorities that shape a national funder's policy direction. I convene and lead consultations with community leaders, researchers, and health experts, synthesizing their input into recommendations for senior decision-makers; the same policy research, stakeholder consultation, and information-synthesis work this role asks for, applied to health data strategy instead of research funding.

I also bring direct experience leading research that gets used for policy-relevant recommendations. At CAREX Canada, I led studies on occupational and environmental exposure risks — including carcinogen exposure among new and immigrant workers and lead in BC school drinking water, producing evidence used to inform exposure-reduction recommendations, while working with linked administrative datasets of more than 100 million records and assessing their quality and limitations so findings could support sound conclusions. As Senior Coordinator at First Nations Health Authority, I led the BC First Nations Regional Health Survey, negotiating data-governance and logistics arrangements across community and organizational stakeholders to deliver it on schedule under OCAP-compliant data management, and building the relationships and consensus-building this role calls for in engaging ministry partners and external stakeholders on data governance.

My technical grounding in SQL, R, SAS, Python, and health-data governance (OCAP-compliant data management, Statistics Canada's Secure Research Environment) means I bring a practitioner's understanding of the data landscape this Branch is setting policy for, not just a policy generalist's view of it. Combined with a peer-reviewed publication record and experience organizing complex technical findings for non-technical and executive audiences, I can move quickly from data-strategy questions to workable policy options.

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how my background in policy-relevant research, stakeholder consultation, and health data governance can support the Branch's work. I appreciate your consideration.

Sincerely,

Disann Katende, MPH